

A FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

ROOM 18

The Year of the Inner Critic

BOOK TWO OF THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

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CHAPTER ONE

Who Am I?



The first thing Marcus noticed about Room 18 was that there was no puppet.

He had not realized, until he stepped through the door on the first morning of third grade, that he had been expecting one. He had walked all the way down the third-grade hallway without once thinking about whether there would be a puppet on a shelf — and there wasn't.

Marcus stood in the doorway a second longer than he needed to. High windows. Round tables instead of rows of desks. Posters that were maps and a periodic table and a thing about the writing process, not the posters from Room 12. A teacher at the front who was not Ms. Calloway.

The teacher was a man.

He had a calm face and a beard going gray at the edges, sleeves rolled to the elbows. He turned from the whiteboard when he saw Marcus in the doorway.

"Marcus," the teacher said.

"How do you know my name?"

"I looked at the roster. And I matched your picture. You're the second one in this morning. Welcome to Room 18. I'm Mr. Patel."

Marcus said hello. He found his name card on a round table and sat down. He looked around the room one more time, just to make sure.

There was no puppet anywhere.

He felt a small sadness about that. He had not known he was going to feel a small sadness, but there it was.

While Mr. Patel was writing the morning schedule, Marcus was thinking about Sammy. He had not thought about Sammy in maybe a year. He realized he had been carrying, all summer, a small expectation that some part of Sammy would be in third grade with him too.

The expectation had been wrong. That was okay. But it was a feeling. He filed it.

Then the door opened again, and Amara walked in.

She saw Marcus and smiled. They had not been in the same class in second grade, and they had not seen much of each other over the summer. But the kids who had been in Ms. Calloway's class in first grade always recognized each other in the hallway. There was a small invisible thing that connected them.

“Hi,” said Amara.

“Hi,” said Marcus.

Amara found her name card two tables over. She sat down, arranged her pencils, looked around. She also noticed there was no puppet.

Across the room, just for a second, their eyes met, and something passed between them that meant *I see what you see*.

Over the next ten minutes, the rest of the class filtered in. Sofia with her hair in a complicated braid, already holding her stomach with one hand the way she always did when she was nervous — though she was much better at her stomach than she used to be. Priya with a small spiral notebook in addition to her regular supplies. Darius in a red shirt over a slightly different red shirt, which was a Darius thing. Jordan laughing at something nobody had said yet. Maya very quietly, on her grandmother’s hand, and her grandmother said *hello, sweet girl* and stood at the door for a moment looking in before she left. (Mr. Patel saw it. He filed it. Teachers who are good at their jobs file things.)

Theo came in last. He always came in last — not because he was late but because he liked to watch the room fill up before he chose where to sit. He sat down at the only table where his name card was already placed, having clearly planned, in his head, where he would have sat if he had a choice.

Marcus, who was watching, smiled to himself. Some things did not change.

But — and this was strange — some things had.

Mia was not there.

Marcus looked under the tables. He looked at the door. He waited. Mia did not come in.

Then the bell rang, and Mr. Patel said, “Welcome to Room 18,” and Marcus realized that Mia was not in this class. He had been a little bit looking forward to Mia all summer.

(She was in another third-grade class down the hall — Marcus would find out at lunch. But for the first hour of the morning, he sat at his table and felt the small absence. It is funny how a person you have not seen in three months can leave a hole in a room you did not know you had been holding for them.)

Then Mr. Patel said, “Friends, before we do anything else, I want to introduce someone.”

He nodded at the door.

The door opened, and a woman walked in, and Marcus’s whole body, without his permission, sat up straight.

It was Ms. Calloway.

She was wearing the same green cardigan she had worn the very first day of first grade, holding a small clipboard. Her hair was a little shorter. She smiled at the room.

“Hi, friends,” she said.

The kids who had been in her class made a small involuntary sound. Marcus made it. Even Theo made a small surprised face, which for Theo was the equivalent of jumping up and down.

Ms. Calloway said, “Mr. Patel is going to be your homeroom teacher this year, and he is wonderful. You are very lucky. But I have a new job at this school. My new job is that I work with the third, fourth, and fifth grades on the part of you that doesn’t show up on a math test. Just like we did in first grade. Once a week, for about forty minutes, I am going to come to Room 18, and we are going to work on the inside of your life.”

She looked around the room.

“Some of you were in my class. Hi. I missed you. I am very glad to see you again.”

She did not point at them. She just looked at each of them — Marcus, Amara, Sofia, Priya, Darius, Jordan, Maya, Theo, Kezia — for one beat, her eyes had something in them, and then she moved on. (Mia was down the hall.)

Marcus felt held.

“Some of you were not in my class. Hi. I am happy to meet you. Today I do not need anything from you except to be here. We are going to start small.”

She picked up a stack of papers from Mr. Patel's desk. "Today we are doing the Identity Web."

A few of the kids who had been in her class smiled. Marcus remembered his first one, in first grade, with the words I HAVE A SISTER, AALIYAH, AGE 3 in big crooked letters along one of the branches.

But the Web she was handing out today had five branches, not the three he remembered:

*Things I Love. Things I'm Good At. Things That Matter to Me.
People Don't Know This About Me. Things I'm Still Figuring Out.*

Marcus stared at the last branch.

"Friends," Ms. Calloway said, "you might notice this Web is a little different from the one some of you did in first grade. It has a new branch this year. Things I'm Still Figuring Out. That is on purpose. You are eight and nine years old now. You are starting to have questions about yourself that you did not have when you were six. That is good. That is exactly where you are supposed to be."

Marcus hovered over the new branch. *Things I'm Still Figuring Out.*

The first thing that came into his head was: *whether I should still tell people I draw comics, or whether comics are babyish.*

He had, in fact, drawn a whole comic over the summer. Twelve pages. A kid who could turn into a bird whenever he was embarrassed. He had been very proud of it. His dad had said *Marcus, this is wonderful*, and his mom had stuck the first page on the fridge with a magnet. But last week, on the bus, a fifth-grader had asked him what he had done over the summer, and Marcus had said *I made a comic*, and the kid had said *uh, isn't that for like babies?*

Marcus had said nothing. The conversation had not lasted thirty seconds. He had been thinking about it for six days.

He wrote, in his careful third-grade handwriting: *Whether the things I like are still allowed to be the things I like, even if older kids say they aren't.*

It looked very honest, sitting there on the paper. He almost erased it. He did not.

He turned, very slightly, to look at Ms. Calloway, and she was looking at him from across the room, and she gave him a small private nod. She was too far to read what he had written. She was just acknowledging that he was writing something honest. That was enough.

Marcus filled in the other branches. *Things I Love*: my sister Aaliyah, drawing, my dog Cleo, soccer, books about dragons. *Things I'm Good At*: being a big brother, drawing, finding lost things. (He put drawing on two branches. Mr. Patel walked past, saw it, and gave him a small thumbs up. Marcus felt the thumbs up for the rest of the morning.) *Things That Matter to Me*: being honest, my family, being a good friend. *People Don't Know This About Me*: I cry sometimes at the end of movies even when they aren't sad ones.

He looked at *Things I'm Still Figuring Out* one more time. His honest sentence sat there. He left it.

Then, on his desk, Mr. Patel set down a small index card. Marcus looked up at the board. Ms. Calloway had written in green marker: *On the index card: one true thing about you that often goes unseen.*

Marcus held the card. He thought of several things. Some small, like *I sometimes count steps when I walk*. Some big, like *I am scared of getting in trouble more than anyone in my family thinks*. Then he thought of one true thing.

He picked up his pencil and wrote, in his neatest handwriting: *I am working on being a person who tells the truth even when it costs me something.*

He almost — almost — crumpled it.

But Ms. Calloway came past at exactly that moment, in the way she had of always coming past at exactly that moment, and she said softly, “Whatever you wrote is good, Marcus. Post it.”

He stood up. He walked, on legs that suddenly felt a little wobbly, to the wall at the back of the room. He put his card in the middle. He walked back to his seat and sat down.

He was, in some small private way, terrified. The card was the most honest thing he had ever put on a wall.

He did not know yet that this was exactly what Ms. Calloway and Mr. Patel had been hoping for — not for Marcus specifically, but for somebody. Somebody had to be the first one. The rest of the class would follow that lead.

By the end of the lesson, all twenty-six cards were on the wall. Some silly. Some brave. Marcus’s was both. Ms. Calloway stood in front of the wall and read them quietly, to herself, without saying anything aloud. Then she turned to the class.

“This is who we are. Look at it for a second.” The kids looked. “This is Room 18. Twenty-six different kinds of person on this wall. Twenty-six different ways of being a third-grader. There is no one right way. There is just — every one of yours. We are going to spend the year getting to know what each of these cards means.”

Then she said, “Welcome to the year.” She nodded at Mr. Patel. Mr. Patel said, “Math books out.” The rest of the morning was math. But the wall stayed there, with the cards on it, and Marcus, every time he walked past it that day, looked at the middle, where his card was, and felt a small private flutter in his chest.

END OF THE FIRST-CHAPTER PREVIEW

The whole year will be in the figuring.

Room 18 — The Year of the Inner Critic

Book Two of the five-book companion series to *The Architecture of Grace*